

The Matching Effect between Narrative Style and Narrative Person of Brands in International Communication

Abstract: The international communication of brand has become an important issue in international trade. In this context, this paper chooses two important communication variables, brand narrative style and narrative person, to discuss the matching effect between brand narrative style (warmth vs. ability) and narrative person (first-person vs. third-person) and its impact on overseas audiences. In this paper, the main effect research based on big data crawling, laboratory experiment research on mediating effect and cross-cultural experimental research on regulating effect are carried out respectively. It is found that the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person has a significant impact on consumer brand attitude. As for the warm brand narrative, compared with the third-person, the first-person narrative is helpful to improve consumers' brand attitude; For competency-based brand narrative, compared with the first-person, the third-person narrative is helpful to improve consumers' brand attitude. Information processing fluency has a mediating effect on the process. The interactive impact of brand narrative style and narrative person on overseas consumers' brand attitudes is moderated by the cultural distance between the home country and the host country. This matching effect is more significant for overseas consumers with close cultural distance, while it is less significant for overseas consumers with far cultural distance.

Keywords: Brand Narrative, Narrative Person, Brand Internationalization, Construal Level Theory, Stereotype Model

Introduction

The deepening of economic globalization has led multinational corporations from emerging markets to play an increasingly important role in cross-border investments and international trade(Luo & Tung, 2018). However, these companies still face challenges in brand building, including low awareness, limited influence, and low brand value. In the world environment of ongoing international trade disputes, cross-cultural brand building is inseparable from the communication of product information through advertising in international marketing. Brands need to adopt specific strategies in different international markets to convey different brand concepts and product information based on actual conditions. Yet, research on this issue remains limited. In the practice of brand internationalization, consumers often encounter brand stories that combine elements of characters, time, space, and various narrative strategies(Milfeld & Flint, 2020;Woodside, 2013). The positive brand attitude and purchase intention of host country consumers form the basis for brands to establish sustainable competitive advantages in complex international markets(Magnusson et al., 2015). The effective combination of brand story elements and narrative strategies is crucial in capturing consumers' minds in the international market; otherwise, it may backfire.

Both material and narrative strategies can be employed to capture new markets. (Humphreys, 2010). However, existing research on brand internationalization has primarily focused on material strategies, neglecting narrative strategies(Huang, 2017). Narrative strategies for brands in international communication have not been extensively researched. Brands communicate their core values and emotions to consumers through narratives, and companies shape their brands through these stories(Granitz & Forman, 2015; T. Wang et al., 2011; Shi et al., 2016). In the field of brand internationalization, only a few narrative studies have addressed the role of elements in

brand narratives as part of global localization strategies(Zong & Zhang, 2020). Different brand narrative styles and communication strategies have an impact on consumer brand perceptions, etc. Treating brand narratives as a single dimension oversimplifies their complexity. Brand narratives consist of multiple dimensions and cannot be viewed as a single entity. Interactions between different dimensions within a brand narrative may also impact a brand's international communication.

Narrative style is a crucial element of a brand's story. Narratives that highlight weaknesses can improve consumers' perceptions of the brand's motives, while narratives that demonstrate strength can enhance perceptions of competence(Li & Zhao, 2021) and focus on brand strength and product quality(T. Wang et al., 2017). Narrative person also a key part of a brand's narrative, and the use of different narrative persons will have a direct impact on consumers' attitudes towards the brand(Sela et al., 2012) their behavioral choices(Ding et al., 2021). However, previous studies have only examined one aspect of the relationship between brand narratives and consumers or host countries. They have not explored the interaction between different elements within brand narratives. This raises a new research question: does the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person affect consumer attitudes towards the brand in international communication?

This study aims to investigate the communication effects of different narrative styles in brand internationalization communication. The brand narrative styles are classified into competence and warmth according to the stereotype model. The study explores their effects on consumer attitudes and whether audiences react differently to these two different brand narratives. Additionally, the psychological mechanisms behind these effects are examined. This study will investigate whether consumers' attitudes towards different brand narratives are influenced by the narrator's person. It will focus on the matching effect between brand narrative style and narrative person, and introduce

the construal level theory and perceptual fluency to explore the psychological mechanism and the boundary of the matching effect.

Theoretical Background and Research Hypothesis

Brand Narrative Style

Narrative construction is the process of creating and updating cognitive patterns in the brain. (Downing & Dron, 2020) In the field of brand international communication, scholars have explored the issue of brand narrative from various perspectives, including communication strategy and social culture. However, interdisciplinary integration research is still in its early stages. Narrative research on international communication suggests that the narrative mode is not an objective, value-neutral product. Stories are closely related to social culture (Herman, 2003). In international communication, language choices, perspectives, and interpretation strategies are influenced by socio-cultural factors. Different national cultural archetypal resources can lead to the construction of various strategies for brand international communication narratives(Liu et al., 2020). Brand narratives have an impact on brand image (Ryu et al., 2019b), brand attitudes(Carnevale et al., 2018), and purchase intentions(Nagar, 2019). Brand association strategies can influence local consumer attitudes by affecting consumer empathy(T. Wang et al., 2017). Appropriate use of storytelling genres and effective use of elements can enhance the reputation of national brands(Guo et al., 2020). and the brand attitude of international consumers(He et al., 2014). Additional research has investigated the connotations of storytelling, thematic types, and the composition of elements in narratives. This includes story typology(Lin & Chen, 2015), character types (Dessart, 2018), narrative language, and visual presentation (Lien & Chen, 2013), and so on. There is an interaction between different old brand narratives that emphasize culture and craftsmanship, as well as different types of brand concepts(D. Wang et al.,

2021). The type of story(M. Shen et al., 2021) and the authenticity of the narrative material(Bu et al., 2023) can influence consumer preferences. Important elements in the composition of a brand's story include character, plot, time, and place. Consumers are influenced by factors such as the time and place of the story(Woodside, 2013).

Most studies on brand narrative style classify it as either weak or strong. Weak narratives convey the brand's enthusiasm and determination to overcome disadvantages in order to establish the brand. Strong narratives, on the other hand, highlight the brand's strengths in terms of opportunities and funds, and emphasize the brand's success in establishing itself due to its outstanding strengths. Under this categorization, the brand's country of origin and consumer visibility interact with its narrative style, influencing consumer perceptions and attitudes(Z. Shen & Li, 2019: Li & Zhao, 2021) This paper proposes a classification of the narrative style of brands into competence and warmth, based on the stereotype model.

Stereotypes are social cognitive schemas that consist of fixed ideas and thoughts about the characteristics of members of a group and their causes. In 2002, Fiske et al. proposed the content model of stereotypes based on the intergroup function of stereotypes. According to this model, an individual's stereotypes of others can be divided into two dimensions: competence and enthusiasm. When individuals encounter others, they instinctively want to know their behavioral intentions and ability to achieve them, specifically their levels of enthusiasm and competence. The perception of warmth arises from information such as friendliness, sincerity, and gentleness, while the perception of competence arises from information such as self-confidence, intelligence, and efficiency(Fiske et al., 2002).

Kervyn proposed a subjective framework of branding based on this model and introduced it into the field of brand research. In this framework, brands are viewed as intentional subjects, and

consumers can assess a brand's perceived intentions and competencies, which trigger different emotions and drive differentiated brand behaviors. Consumer perceptions of a brand can be summed up by the two dimensions of warmth and competence(Kervyn et al. , 2012). These two dimensions of brand stereotyping can influence consumers' perceptions of functional, emotional, and social value. These perceptions can then be reflected in their purchase intentions and brand ownership (Kolbl et al., 2020) , and can have a greater impact than even localized or globalized brand positioning (Hal.kias et al., 2016). This topic has been extensively researched in the field of marketing and consumer behavior. Studies have shown that consumers tend to view not-for-profit organizations as warm brands and for-profit organizations as competence brands. Therefore, when promoting competence brands, rational appeals are more effective, while emotional appeals may be more suitable for warm brands(Chen et al., 2021); This brand perception further influences the choice of the brand's anthropomorphic image as well as its logo(Ye & Shi, 2020).

According to the stereotype content model, this study classifies brand narratives into two dimensions: competence-based and warmth-based. Among them, competence-based brand narratives refer to the attributes of high competence, intelligence, trustworthiness and competitiveness that brands highlight through narratives, and warmth-based brand narratives refer to the attributes of warmth, enthusiasm and friendliness that brands highlight through narratives.

Narrative Person

Narrative person refers to the various forms of personal pronouns, which can be divided into first, second and third-person according to the different subjects of the narrative. The first narrative person refers to the narrative subject who describes the events experienced or conveys his or her own information with 'I, we' as the center; the second narrative person refers to the narrative subject who describes the events with 'you, you'; and the third narrative person refers to the

narrative subject who stands in the objective perspective of the third-person in the process of dialogue and conveys the experiences of other people(Chang et al. 2019). Related studies from the perspective of literature and information transmission emphasize the first and third-person narratives, the first-person focusing on personal experience and practical feelings, which is more realistic and makes the article narrative intimate and natural, and the relationship between the audience and the narrated event is closer, While the third-person describes and conveys the information from a purely objective point of view, which is free from the limitations of the environment and the conditions of expression, and can introduce the information and the real situation in a more detailed, comprehensive and accurate way, although the audience is farther away from the narrated event, it can reflect the relevant content accurately and comprehensively from an objective point of view. The third-person is based on a purely objective point of view to describe and convey information, not limited by the circumstances and conditions of expression, can be more detailed, comprehensive and accurate information and the real situation, although the audience and the narrative events of the distance, but more from an objective point of view of the relevant content of an accurate and comprehensive reflection(Chang et al., 2019b).

The narrative person is an important means of defining the center of the dialogue and can strengthen the perception of the quality of the relationship between the two parties to the dialogue(Cook, 1992). The use of first-person narratives in marketing helps to build product image, connect with consumers and increase brand trust and goodwill(Fairclough, 2013). At the same time, the first-person narrative restores the real communication scene and shortens the psychological distance between the consumer and the brand(Cook, 1992). The effect of singular and plural first-person has also been explored in research, with singular first-person apologies being more effective in corporate apologies for competence-related errors, and plural first-person apologies being better

for ethical errors(Xie et al., 2022). The third-person in brand narratives, usually told from outside the story, is more persuasive because it is more authentic and objective. In contextual narratives with negative valence, the third-person is more effective than the first-person. The role of narrative person in branding is currently receiving increasing attention, but in addition to the specific contexts mentioned above, existing research has paid less attention to the combinatorial relationship between the use of person and other marketing variables, such as those mentioned above, and narrative style in branding in a more general brand marketing context. Based on this, this study divides narrative person into first and third-person and analyses the role of narrative person in the relationship between brand narrative style and brand attitude.

Construal Level Theory and The Interactive Effect of Brand Narrative Style and Narrative Person

The brand's narrative style affects how consumers process the message, with more empowering or warmer narratives eliciting different feelings in consumers, which in turn affects their level of construction of the message (Liberman & Trope, 1998). High levels of Construal have a greater preference for abstract, structured, core superordinate concepts, while low levels of construction have a preference for concrete, unstructured, superficial subordinate concepts(Liberman et al., 2007). The degree to which individuals interpret information varies with psychological distance; the closer the description is perceived in space and time and the higher the probability of occurrence, using the self as a point of reference, the more likely they are to adopt a low degree of construction, and conversely, the greater the spatial and temporal distance from society and the lower the probability of occurrence, the more likely individuals are to adopt a high degree of construction(Trope & Liberman, 2010). Changes in the level of construction affect the individual's cognitive activities such as judgement, prediction and evaluation, and if the individual's level of construction is consistent with what is happening, the individual will have a

more positive attitude.

Different narrative perspectives determine different ways of discourse and also different ways of feeling for the audience. In brand marketing, the use of the first-person for advertising, friendly and natural tone of voice can effectively bring consumers closer to the psychological distance of the brand, this close psychological distance makes it easier for consumers to adopt a lower level of construction to understand the information; while the use of the third-person can be introduced between the brand and the consumer a new individual, so as to build a longer distance between the consumer and the scenarios, so that the consumer tends to use higher levels of construction to perceive the acquired information. level of construction to perceive the acquired information. In this case, consumers may see the brand as a social role and their focus will be more on the brand's performance in achieving professional goals and providing professional services, while less emphasis will be placed on the brand's emotional connection with individuals. The emotional connection between the brand and the individual is less important and the brand is perceived as a functional brand rather than an emotional partner, which creates a greater psychological distance and leads to a preference for a high level of construction when obtaining information.

It follows that when brands engage in warm brand narratives or use first-person narratives, both correspond to low levels of consumer construction, whereas when brands engage in competence brand narratives or use third-person narratives, both correspond to high levels of consumer construction. This study argues that, given this theoretical premise, consumers will have better brand attitudes when the brand's narrative style matches the level of construction of the Narrative person.

On this basis, hypothesis 1 is proposed:

H1: The interactive effect of brand narrative person strategy and narrative style significantly influences consumers' brand attitudes:

H1a: For warm brand narratives, the use of first-person narratives helps to improve consumers' brand attitudes compared to the use of third-person narratives.

H1b: For competence-based brand narratives, the use of third-person narratives helps to increase consumers' brand attitudes compared to the use of first-person narratives.

Mediating effects of information processing fluency

The narrative person influences consumers' different preferences for the brand's narrative style by influencing their level of construction of the brand's narrative. When the narrative person matches the brand's narrative style, consumers have a similar psychological distance between the two elements and are able to adopt the same level of construction, and this match will positively influence the consumer's experience of processing information fluently.

Information processing fluency refers to the perceived ease with which an individual processes information (Jacoby & Dal.las, 1981) and can positively influence an individual's evaluation of the information processing object(Winkielman et al., 2003). Fluent information processing can evoke positive emotions in the unconscious state of the individual, so that the individual tends to misattribute this positive emotion to the object of information processing, thus developing a greater preference for the object of information processing(Schwarz, 2006). In the brand marketing of this study, when the narrative personmatches the narrative style to a higher degree, consumers will have higher information processing fluency and the positive emotions it evokes, which may be misattributed to the brand, and consumers may have higher brand recognition and brand attitudes, i.e. the higher the fluency, the better the brand attitudes accordingly, when processing the information related to the brand's narrative.

On this basis, hypothesis 2 is proposed:

H2: Information processing fluency has a mediating effect in the interaction between brand narrative person strategy and narrative style on consumers' brand attitudes:

H2a: For warm brand narratives, the use of first-person narratives will positively influence consumer brand attitudes by increasing information processing fluency compared to the use of third-person narratives.

H2b: For competence-based brand narratives, the use of third-person narratives will positively influence consumer attitudes by increasing consumers' information processing fluency compared to the use of first-person narratives.

Moderating Effects of Cultural Distance between Countries

Cultural distance refers to the degree of difference between the cultural norms of one country and those of another (Kogut & Singh, 1988a). Cultural distance between countries in international communication. In international communication, cultural distance between countries is related to cultural types, political and economic systems and value systems (Zhang & Zhang, 2017). Its existence creates an asymmetry of information between the two countries, an asymmetry that makes the exchange of information more difficult, which in turn increases the psychological distance between the two sides (Slangen, 2006). That is, when the cultural distance is closer, the corresponding psychological distance will also be closer, in which case consumers may be more sensitive to the sincerity-based brand narrative and the first-person match ability perception, which also belong to the close psychological distance and low level of construction; while when the cultural distance between countries is greater, the psychological distance between the brand and consumers will also be greater, and the level of construction of the relevant information will be higher, then it may be more sensitive to the competence-based narrative and the third-person match

ability perception will be more sensitive.

On this basis, hypothesis 3 is proposed:

H3: The effect of the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person on consumer attitudes is moderated by cultural distance between countries:

H3a: For culturally distant consumers, consumers will perceive a higher fit for the combination of competence narrative and third-person narrative than for the combination of warmth narrative and first-person narrative.

H3b: For culturally distant consumers, consumers perceive a higher match for the combination of warmth narratives and first-person narratives compared to the combination of competence narratives and third-person narratives.

Research Methodology

This study tests the relevant hypotheses through big data crawling and analysis, and two experiments. Study 1 aimed to examine the interaction effects of narrative style and narrative person on consumers' brand attitudes through the internationally oriented brand narrative content of brands in reality; Study 2 verified the hypothesized interaction with information processing fluency by manipulating the brand's narrative style and narrative person through the self-designed experimental materials; and Study 3 used a different product from Study 2 to further verify the interaction effect on based on further validation of the interaction, to explore the moderating role of cultural distance between countries.

Study 1

1. Data sources and descriptive statistics. In this study, we use 'Twitter', a global social media platform that has become an important channel for brands and consumers to interact due to its ease of communication and wide reach, where many companies and organizations connect with their

followers. By posting content and interacting with users on Twitter, brands can not only improve their brand narrative and brand awareness, but also deepen the relationship between brands and consumers.

In this study, we obtained tweet data information from the official accounts of nine brands on Twitter, including Huawei, Xiaomi, DJI, Maotai, etc., and the sample selection period is from 1 May 2023 to 31 August 2023. First, we obtained the relevant brands through the list of 'Top 100 Most Valuable Brands in China in 2022' and other lists, and combined with the brand industry to remove the B-end industry, such as banking, finance, steel, and other content platform brands such as Jittery Express, and obtained 24 brands, and then examined the content of the brand's Twitter account, After removing the brands that have no official account on the Twitter platform and the brands with low frequency of interaction of information released by the official account, the remaining 9 brands including Huawei, Xiaomi, DJI, etc. , based on which we crawled the data and information.

We obtained the account content (narrative content, number of words, number of pictures, etc.) and interaction (number of views, number of likes, number of retweets, number of comments, etc.) of these 9 brands during the selected period, and coded the narrative style and narrative person of the brand's Twitter account content. We obtained a total of 1,314 tweets with first and third-person narrative style and narrative style of competence and warmth.

Due to the large gap between the mean and the extreme value of the number of likes, comments and followers of the account, this study took the natural logarithm of the number of views, likes and followers of the account for processing in order to increase the robustness of the results (Insert Table 1 *Descriptive statistics for big data crawl variables*).

2. Measurement modelling. In order to test the research hypotheses H1a and H1b in this paper, a regression model was constructed and since the social media accounts of several brands were selected as the sample for analysis in this study, which would have a random effect, a Mixed Effects Model was used for the analysis in this study. (Rust, 2005) The measurement model is shown below:

First, the relationship between the variables is shown in Equation 1:

$$Lnlike_i = \beta_{0j} + \beta_1stereotype_j + \beta_2narrative_i + \beta_3stereotype_j \times narrative_j + \beta_4 \sum Controls + \varepsilon_{ij} \quad \text{Equation 1}$$

where the fixed effects are shown in Equation 2:

$$Lnlike_i = \beta_1stereotype_j + \beta_2narrative_i + \beta_3stereotype_j \times narrative_i + \beta_4 \sum Controls + \varepsilon_{ij} \quad \text{Equation 2}$$

The random effects are shown in Equation 3:

$$\beta_{0j} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1brand_j + \sigma_j \quad \text{Equation 3}$$

3. Findings. This study used the Stata package to build a linear mixed effects model (Insert Table 1 *The interactive effect of brand narrative style and narrative person*). The results show that the interaction effect of brand narrative style and narrative person has a positive and significant effect on the number of likes (M3, $\beta = -0.927$, $SE = 0.241$, $p < 0.01$), i.e. for competence-based brand narratives, choosing the third-person brand narrative is more likely to increase consumers' attitudes towards the brand; for warmth-based brand narratives, choosing the first-person brand narrative is more likely to increase consumers' attitudes towards the brand. Meanwhile, M3 has a lower AIC value compared to M1 and M2, indicating that M3 is a better fit, which confirms hypotheses H1a and H1b.

Robustness test. In order to increase the robustness and reliability of the analysis results of this study, we choose the number of retweets as the dependent variable of the model and verify the results again. The results show that the interaction effect of brand narrative style and narrative person has a positive and significant effect on the number of retweets at this point (M6, $\beta = -0.351$, $SE = 0.163$, $p < 0.01$). Meanwhile, M6 has a lower AIC value compared to M4 & M5, suggesting a better fit for M6 and further supporting hypotheses H1a, H1b.

Study 2

After validation through the study of a large body of data, we experimentally re-examined the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person, and further explored individual psychological mechanisms.

1.Participants. Study 2 used a 2 (brand narrative style: warmth vs. competence) x 2 (narrative person: first-person vs. third-person) between-subjects design. Subjects were randomly assigned to 4 experimental groups and were told that the purpose of this experiment was to measure consumer attitudes, with an age range of 18-69 years and an approximate 7:11 male to female ratio.

2.Procedure. They were then presented with a piece of brand narrative content. We manipulated the narrative person through first or third-person, and the brand narrative style through differences in narrative utterances (i.e., warmth-first-person, warmth-third-person, competence-first-person, competence-third-person). We presented subjects with four sets of brand narratives of virtual cloth shoe brands, as follows: ‘A long-established cloth shoe brand that travels between fashion, culture, and art; **we** sell not only cloth shoes, but also Beijing culture.’; ‘A long-established cloth shoe brand that travels between fashion, culture, and art; **they** sell not only cloth shoes, but also Beijing culture.’; ‘A long-established cloth shoes brand that wanders between quality, skill, and innovation; what's special about these cloth shoes is that **they**'ve adopted an M-

shaped ankle protector upper, which is sufficiently elastic and strong in protection.’; ‘A long-established cloth shoes brand that wanders between quality, skill, and innovation; what's special about these cloth shoes is that we've adopted an M-shaped ankle protector upper, which is sufficiently elastic and strong in protection.’ ..To ensure that the manipulation was valid, a pre-experiment was conducted to test whether the style of the brand narrative reflected brand competence or embodied brand warmth.

3.Measures. Participants were randomly assigned to the four different brands in the experiment and completed statements about their perceptions of the brand's narrative style ('I think this narrative shows that the brand is enthusiastic', 'I think this narrative shows that the brand is competitive', They were also asked to rate their attitudes towards the brand by completing statements such as 'After reading this brand narrative, I have a positive attitude towards the brand', 'After reading this brand narrative, I have a favorable impression of the brand', etc.). In addition, cognitive fluency was also assessed through statements such as ‘I think this brand narrative is simple’ and ‘I think this brand narrative is easy to understand’(A. Y. Lee & Aaker, 2004) To rule out possible alternative mediating explanations consistent with the measure of cognitive fluency, participants completed self-relevance measures.

4. Stimulus Materials. Firstly, it was found that there were no significant differences between participants within each experimental group in terms of gender, age and education. Secondly, an independent samples t-test of participants' preference for the experimental material utterances showed that there were no significant differences between the groups. Finally, an independent samples t-test of the brand narrative style manipulation revealed that participants in the competence group ($M_{\text{competence}} = 6.11$, $SD = 0.44$) reported higher levels of perceived competence ($t(111,580) = 12.148$, $p < 0.001$) than participants in the warmth group ($M_{\text{warmth}} = 4.45$, $SD = 1.22$).

Participants in the warmth group ($M_{\text{warmth}}=6.07$, $SD=0.48$) reported higher levels of perceived warmth ($t(120.554)=13.691$, $p<0.001$) than participants in the ability group ($M_{\text{competence}}=4.32$, $SD=1.12$). Thus, the manipulation was successful in Study 2.

5. Hypothesis testing. We first examined the effect of brand narrative style on subjects' brand attitudes and found that brand narrative style had no significant effect on subjects' brand attitudes ($M_{\text{competence}}=5.78$, $SD=0.55$, $M_{\text{warmth}}=5.81$, $SD=0.80$; $F(1,178)=0.80$, $p=0.778$). Similarly, there was no significant effect of brand narrative person on subjects' brand attitudes ($M_{\text{Third}} = 5.74$, $SD = 0.76$, $M_{\text{First}} = 5.84$, $SD = 0.60$; $F(1,178) = 0.959$, $p = 0.329$).

To test the effect of matching brand narrative style and narrative person on subjects' brand attitudes, we used a two-way ANOVA test to test the interaction effect with brand attitude as the dependent variable. The results showed that the interaction of brand narrative style and narrative person had a significant effect on subjects' brand attitude ($F(1,176)=48.556$, $p<0.001$), and H1 was validated. Subsequent comparative analyses showed that for the competence narrative style, the brand adopted the third-person and subjects' brand attitudes were more positive ($M_{\text{Third}} = 6.04$, $SD = 0.44$; $M_{\text{First}} = 5.51$, $SD = 0.52$; $F(1,88) = 27.45$, $p<0.001$), with H1a being validated, and for the warmth narrative style, the brand adopted the first-person and subjects' brand attitudes were more positive ($M_{\text{First}} = 6.17$, $SD = 0.48$; $M_{\text{Third}} = 5.44$, $SD = 0.89$; $F(1,88) = 23.72$, $p<0.001$), with H1b being validated (Insert Figure 1 *The Interactive Effect of Brand Narrative Style and Narrative Person*).

A 2 (brand narrative style: warmth, competence) $\times$ 2 (narrative person: first-person, third-person) ANOVA for information processing fluency revealed a significant interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person ($F(1,176)=81.79$, $p<0.001$). For the competence narrative style, subjects showed higher information processing fluency when confronted with third-person

narratives ($M_{\text{Third}}=6.08$, $SD=0.37$, $M_{\text{First}}=5.23$, $SD=0.65$; $F(1,88)=58.80$, $p<0.001$); whereas for the warmth narrative style, subjects showed higher information processing fluency when exposed to first-person narratives ($M_{\text{First}}=5.97$, $SD=0.47$, $M_{\text{Third}}=5.21$, $SD=0.81$; $F(1,88)=29.89$, $p<0.001$).

The mediating effect of information processing fluency was further explored in this study using the Process add-in for SPSS (Hayes, 2013). The bias-corrected non-parametric percentile method was selected for sampling, model 8 was selected, the sample size was set at 5000, and the confidence interval was set at 95%. It was found that the interval of the moderated mediated effect did not contain 0 (LLCI=0.201, ULCI=1.306, effect coefficient was 0.755), which indicated the existence of a moderated mediated effect, suggesting that information processing fluency played a mediating role in it, and H2 was initially verified. When the brand narrative style was competence-based, the mediation effect interval did not contain 0 (LLCI=0.650, ULCI=1.110, effect coefficient of 0.397), indicating that a mediation effect existed, and H2a was confirmed; when the brand narrative style was warmth-based, the mediation effect interval did not contain 0 (LLCI=0.083, ULCI=0.670, effect coefficient of 0.358), indicating the presence of a mediation effect, and H2b was confirmed.

Study 3

Having tested the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person and the mediating effect of information processing fluency in Study 3, we designed Study 3 to further explore the limits of the matching effect, i.e. the moderating role of cultural distance between countries.

1. Participants. Study 3 used a 2 (brand narrative style: warmth vs. competence) x 2 (narrative person: first-person vs. third-person) x 2 (cultural distance: near vs. far) between-subjects design. We manipulated cultural distance by changing the nationality of the subjects, with Singapore

chosen as the near cultural distance country and the United States as the far cultural distance country(Kogut & Singh, 1988b). Subjects are randomly assigned to four experimental groups and told that the purpose of the experiment is to measure consumer attitudes, with an age range of 18-69 years and an approximate male/female ratio of 7:12.

2.Procedure. They will then be presented with a piece of brand narrative content. We manipulated the narrative person through first or third-person, and the brand narrative style through differences in narrative utterances (i.e.warmth-first-person, warmth-third-person,competence-first-person,competence-third-person). We presented subjects with four sets of brand narratives for the virtual mobile phone brand *Myphone*, ‘Myphone is a friendly, sincere and approachable mobile phone brand; always meticulously accompanied, **I** will remember every moment of goodness’; ‘Myphone is a friendly, sincere and approachable mobile phone brand; always meticulously accompanied, **it** will remember every moment of goodness’;.’Myphone is a superb, reliable and confident mobile phone brand; keeping up with the times and breaking the boundaries, **I** am equipped with excellent performance and unparalleled innovation’; ‘Myphone is a superb, reliable and confident mobile phone brand; keeping up with the times and breaking the boundaries, **it** is equipped with excellent performance and unparalleled innovation’. To ensure the validity of the manipulation, a pre-experiment was conducted to test whether brand narrative style reflected brand competence or brand warmth.

3.Measures. Participants were randomly assigned to the four different brands in the experiment, completed statements about their perceptions of the brand's narrative style (‘I think this narrative shows that the brand is warm’, ‘I think this narrative shows that the brand is competitive’, etc.), and were asked to rate their attitudes towards the brand. ‘After reading this brand narrative, I have a positive attitude towards the brand’, ‘After reading this brand narrative,

I have a favorable opinion of the brand' and 'I have a favorable opinion of the brand', 'After reading this brand narrative, I have a favorable opinion of the brand. '

4. Stimulus Materials. Firstly, it was found that there were no significant differences between participants within each experimental group in terms of gender, age and education. Secondly, an ANOVA analysis of participants' liking of the images and language of the experimental material showed that there were no significant differences between the groups. Finally, using an independent samples t-test to analyze the brand narrative style manipulation, participants in the competence narrative group ($M_{\text{competence}} = 6.00$, $SD = 1.20$) reported higher perceived competence scores than participants in the warmth narrative group ($M_{\text{warmth}} = 3.97$, $SD = 1.24$) ($t(263.961) = 13.585$, $p < 0.001$). Participants in the warmth narrative group ($M_{\text{warmth}} = 6.13$, $SD = 1.23$) reported higher perceived warmth scores ($t(263.979) = 13.920$, $p < 0.001$) than participants in the competence narrative group ($M_{\text{competence}} = 4.04$, $SD = 1.22$). Thus, the manipulation of Study 3 was successful.

5. Hypothesis testing. First, a three-way ANOVA was conducted on narrative style, narrative person and cultural distance. The results showed a significant interaction effect of cultural distance, narrative style and narrative person ($F(1, 258) = 7.787$, $p < 0.01$), indicating that there are significant differences in the effects of narrative style and narrative person on host country consumers' brand attitudes in overseas markets with different cultural distances. In close cultural distance overseas markets, the ANOVA results showed a significant interaction effect of narrative style and narrative person ($F(1, 131) = 37.769$, $p < 0.001$). In culturally distant overseas markets, the ANOVA results showed a significant interaction effect between narrative style and narrative person ($F(1, 127) = 2.368$, $p = 0.126$) (Insert Figure 2 *Moderating Effects of Cultural Distance between Countries*).

In overseas markets with closer cultural distance, the interaction between warmth narrative and first-person can enhance overseas consumers' attitudes towards brands, while the interaction between competence narrative and third-person cannot significantly enhance overseas consumers' attitudes towards brands. However, in overseas markets that are culturally distant, both interaction effects are no longer significant, so this experiment partially supports H3, specifically H3a is significant while H3b is significant.

Summary

Findings

In this study, based on the stereotype content model, brand narratives are classified into competence narratives and warmth narratives according to their narrative style. On this basis, we proposed the matching effect between brand narrative style and narrative person, and explained its information mechanism from the perspective of information processing fluency, and also explored the moderating role of cultural distance between countries as the boundary of the matching effect. Through two experiments, we confirmed that brand narrative style and narrative person interact on brand attitudes. For warm brand narratives, the use of first-person narratives helps to enhance consumers' brand attitudes compared to the use of third-person narratives; while for competence brand narratives, the use of third-person narratives helps to enhance consumers' brand attitudes compared to the use of first-person narratives. Information processing fluency plays a mediating role, and when the warmth narrative style is matched with the first-person narrative or the competence narrative style is matched with the third-person narrative (i.e., low level of construction and close psychological distance or high level of construction and far psychological distance), consumers have higher information processing fluency, which leads to more positive brand attitudes. Cultural distance between countries moderates this interaction effect. In overseas

markets with closer cultural distance, the interactions of warmth narrative and first-person are more significant in enhancing overseas consumers' attitudes towards brands, while the interactions of competence narrative and third-person do not significantly enhance overseas consumers' attitudes towards brands. In culturally distant markets, both interactions do not significantly enhance overseas consumers' attitudes towards brands.

Theoretical contributions and managerial insights

This study explores the influence of brand narrative style on consumers' brand attitudes based on the level of construction theory, and the theoretical contributions are mainly in the following three aspects. First, this study classifies brand narrative style into competence and warmth based on the stereotype content model. This not only complements the existing commonly used brand narrative style classification model of showing weakness or showing strength, but also expands the application scope of the stereotype model in the field of branding, and lays the theoretical foundation for the proposed matching effect of brand narrative style and narrative person. On this basis, this study verifies the interaction between brand narrative style and narrative person on consumers' brand attitudes and its psychological mechanism, and then extends the matching variable of brand narrative style from the country of origin of the brand. Consumers and so on to other elements within the brand narrative, which is an important addition to the existing brand narrative research and further improves the brand narrative theoretical framework.

Second, this study theoretically enriches interdisciplinary brand narrative research. Most of the existing research on narrative strategy focuses on qualitative research in the fields of communication and literature(D. Shen, 2022). There is a lack of specific research in the context of brand globalization practices. While some research has pointed to the impact of narrative person

in branding on audience attitudes and behavioral intentions, moderated by brand anthropomorphism and situational valence(Stern, 1991). However, there is still a lack of in-depth exploration of the contexts related to the use of narrative person, in particular whether narrative person changes other communication variables. Literary studies have emphasized the impact of the choice of narrative person on narrative effects, while the choice of narrative person for brand narratives is more concerned with how narrative person affects the relationship construction and message delivery between brands and consumers. Applying the theoretical frameworks of communication and literature to the field of brand narratives, this study enriches the intersection of communication and literary studies by introducing the level of construction theory and cognitive fluency, and discussing the effects of the interaction between narrative style and narrative person on brand attitudes in brand narratives.

Finally, this study finds the moderating effect of intercultural distance between countries on the above brand narrative interactions, which provides a new theoretical perspective for understanding brand communication effects in cross-cultural settings. While current research has rarely explored the construction and mechanism of brand narrative strategies in international communication, this study combines narrative style and narrative person, which are two key variables in brand narratives, to analyze the relationship between their interaction and cultural distance, providing a more comprehensive perspective and theoretical explanation in the field of brand internationalization.

In addition to the above theoretical contributions, this study also sheds light on the narrative strategies of brands when exploring international markets. The study suggests that matching similar levels of construction in narratives can enhance consumers' information processing fluency in brand narratives, thereby promoting the formation of positive brand attitudes. This provides

guidance for the construction of brand narrative strategy. Brands can choose either competence or warmth narrative style according to the target market and positioning characteristics, and at the same time select the appropriate narrative person in a targeted way to enhance consumers' brand identification and preference. In addition, in brand internationalization communication, the brand should pay attention to the differences in narrative perception of consumers from different cultural backgrounds. When facing markets with different cultural distances, brand managers need to choose appropriate narrative strategies according to the matching of consumers' perceptions of different combinations of narrative styles, and adjust the narrative styles and narrative person according to the cultural characteristics of the target market.

Research limitations and future directions

This study mainly classifies the narrative style of brand narratives based on the stereotype content model, and then discusses the match between brand narrative style and narrative person based on the level of construction theory, but there may be other mediators to influence the choice of narrative person in brand narratives under the perception of brand competence and warmth, such as the study points out from the perspective of consumer motivation in social media match between brand image and narrative person (Chang et al., 2019). Subsequently, the investigation of other mediators of brand perceptual matching under the stereotype-based content model delineation with the effects on consumer behavior can be continued to further enrich the existing research. Secondly, this study focused on the first and third-person in its examination of the brand narrative person, while not addressing the consideration of the second person. As a more direct mode of communication, the second person with its dialogic narrative may have an important impact on consumers' emotional resonance and brand identity. Future research could further extend the scope of the study by considering the use of the second person in brand narratives to explore

its impact on consumer attitudes. Finally, existing research has found that brand narratives should be constructed according to different national cultural archetypal resources(Liu et al., 2020). Does the combined use of narrative style and narrative person work differently for different national cultural archetypes, and does the stage of internationalization of the brand affect the effectiveness of this match? By exploring these questions, the findings of this paper can be organically combined with existing theories to gain a deeper and more comprehensive understanding of the combinatorial relationships and contextual factors of multiple variables in advertising narratives.

Table 1 Descriptive statistics for big data crawl variables

Variable Name	Sample Size	Mean	Standard Deviation	Minimum value	Maximum value
Brand Narrative Style	1314	0.87	0.34	0	1
Brand Narrative Person	1314	0.45	0.50	0	1
Ln Views	1314	13.40	14.74	0	17.37
Ln Likes	1314	6.16	8.07	0	11.27
Number of tweets	1314	24.26	13.17	6	55
Number of followers	1314	6.10	6.12	1.50	6.99
Number of videos	1314	0.25	0.44	0	3
Number of pictures	1314	0.5	0.87	0	4

Note: Brand Narrative Style codes: 0=Competent, 1=Warm; Brand Narrative Person codes: 0=Third-person Narrative, 1=First-person Narrative.

Table 2 The interactive effect of brand narrative style and narrative person

	Dependent variable: Ln views			Dependent variable: number of Ln likes		
	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6
Fixed effects						
Narrative Style		-	-0.270**		-0.119	-0.080
		0.372***				
		(0.117)	(0.120)		(0.079)	(0.081)
Narrative Person		-0.029	-0.044		0.011	0.005
		(0.080)	(0.079)		(0.054)	(0.054)
Interaction Terms			0.927***			0.351**
			(0.241)			(0.163)
Constants	6.272***	6.612***	6.476***	2.676***	2.779***	2.728***
	(0.977)	(0.983)	(0.987)	(0.889)	(0.890)	(0.891)
Control institution						
Ln number of followers	0.775***	0.787***	0.790***	0.459**	0.462**	0.464**
	(0.221)	(0.222)	(0.223)	(0.205)	(0.205)	(0.205)
Number of Ln tweets	0.384***	0.363***	0.365***	-0.038	-0.046	-0.045
	(0.078)	(0.078)	(0.077)	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.052)
Number of videos	0.047	0.058	0.075	0.578***	0.582***	0.588***
	(0.097)	(0.097)	(0.097)	(0.065)	(0.065)	(0.065)
Number of images	-	-	0.151***	0.231***	0.229***	0.233***
	0.157***	0.163***				

	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.035)	(0.035)	(0.035)
Stochastic effects						
Residual	1.952	1.936	1.915	1.237	1.234	1.235
	(0.076)	(0.076)	(0.075)	(0.593)	(0.592)	(0.592)
<i>AIC</i>	1460.37	1362.99	1341.08	303.68	303.07	296.22

Note: N = 1314; standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$; branded narrative style: 1 = warmth, 0 = competence; narrative person: 1 = first-person, 0 = third-person.

Figure1 The Interactive Effect of Brand Narrative Style and Narrative Person

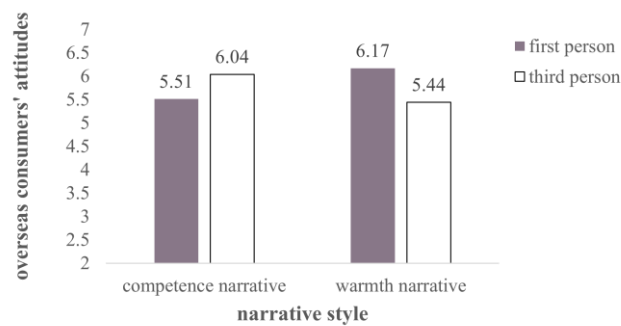
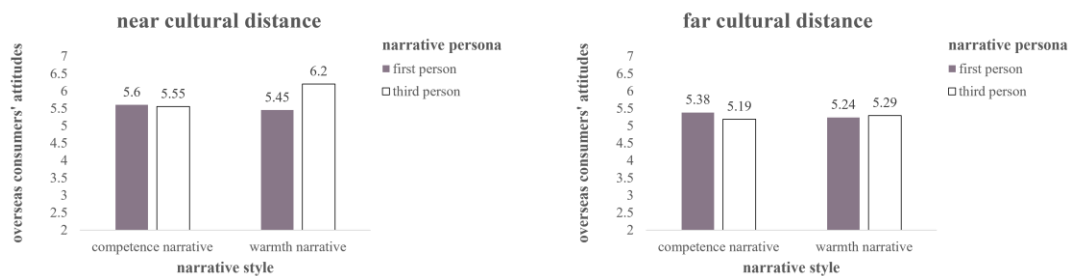


Figure 2 Moderating Effects of Cultural Distance between Countries



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